

Policies

The policies behind your work, in plain language.

For health workers

Key messages

- Papua New Guinea's Vision 2050 aims for a smart, wise, fair, healthy and happy society. The National Health Plan 2021 to 2030 turns this into action.
- Key Result Area 1 of the plan is about developing VHAs to strengthen village and community health services. Village Health Assistance is Intervention No. 1.
- The VHA Policy sets up village health workers as a formal part of the health system. VHAs are paid according to government standards and skill level.
- VHAs are the first point of contact for health promotion, awareness and disease prevention. They link rural and remote communities to the health system.

- VHAs do not give curative treatment. They promote health, give first aid information, and refer.
- Always keep client information private and treat people with respect.

Who is a VHA

- A woman or man chosen by the community, with the ward health committee helping the process, trained and supervised.
- At least 25 years old, of sound mind, and able to walk distances and carry supplies. Grade 10 to 12 is preferred, and at least one VHA in the team must be able to read.
- Has lived in the ward for three years, is respected and responsible, and works well with health workers.
- A minimum of 2 VHAs per ward.

Working hours

- 10 working days each month, out of 22, with 8 hours a day.

- You can choose your own schedule as long as the basic parts of the work are done.

Who supervises you

- Health facility in-charge: technical support, at least monthly at first and every 3 months after.
- Ward councillor and ward health committee: administrative support, about every two weeks.
- Provincial health authority and district health managers: quarterly meetings, approve work plans and pay.
- In some districts, church health organisations also support VHAs.

In an emergency

- Advise the person to go to the nearest health facility at any level. Where you can, go with them.
- Call 111, or call your technical supervisor.
- Emergencies include: not able to wake, seizure or severe head injury, chest pain,

stroke or face or arm weakness, severe trouble breathing, severe bleeding, severe burns, major injury, severe allergic reaction, or a serious assault.

General information only. Follow the advice of your health centre and current national guidelines. Based on the National Department of Health Village Health Assistant (VHA) training curriculum.